Meeting Doubt

God's witness is already in their world

BIG IDEA

God has never left himself without a witness. A skeptic's sense of justice and wonder at the world are already pointing somewhere. And doubt can live inside faith: Jesus came back for Thomas. So we meet doubters with mercy and look for common ground before we argue.

OPENING

A question that stuck

Think of a time you had a doubt or a question about faith that wouldn't go away. What helped? What didn't?

MEETING DOUBT · 1

Never without a witness

Acts 14:15–17

Romans 2:14–15

LISTEN

"Given what I see"

Where is God in Suffering? Jon Steingard & Amy Orr-Ewing

Jon Steingard and Amy Orr-Ewing · Premier Unbelievable? · 11:28–16:44

Jon Steingard was the lead singer of the Christian band Hawk Nelson. In 2020 he announced that he no longer believed in God. Here he tells Amy Orr-Ewing, a Christian writer, what started it. Partway through, the host, Justin Brierley, mentions that he has been to the same place.

Scan to watch

LISTEN FOR

- What Orr-Ewing does before she disagrees with him
- The question she asks about his own reaction

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=feRpdJJ50ds&t=688s

MEETING DOUBT · 2

Your own poets

Acts 17:16–23

Acts 17:24–31

Acts 17:32–34

LISTEN

“What I love about this view”

Does consciousness point to God? Philip Goff & Sharon Dirckx

Philip Goff and Sharon Dirckx · Premier Unbelievable? · 43:20–44:46

Philip Goff is a philosopher who doesn’t believe in God. He thinks consciousness is part of everything, all the way down (a view called panpsychism). Sharon Dirckx is a Christian and a brain scientist. Goff has just finished explaining his view.

Scan to watch

LISTEN FOR

- How she begins
- What she finds in his view that she can agree with

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ef2vvT5GfoE&t=2600s

MEETING DOUBT · 3

Room for Thomas

John 20:24–29

Mark 9:20–27

Matthew 28:16–20

Jude 22–23

LISTEN

“Three more floors”

Reason for God? Belief in an Age of Skepticism | Q&A with Tim Keller at Columbia University

Tim Keller · The Veritas Forum · 1:20:30–1:23:40

Scan to watch

Tim Keller (1950–2023) was a pastor in New York City. At a forum at Columbia University in 2008, near the end of the evening, he was asked what gives him peace. He answers with a story about his own faith and doubt.

LISTEN FOR

- What happened to Keller’s certainty, and to his doubts
- How he says faith, reason, and doubt fit together

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L9jHlrMRJAo&t=4830s

Talk it over

1. Dirckx disagrees with Goff but starts with what she loves about his view. What could you honestly say you love about how the skeptic you know (or any of those ones you have “met” in this class) thinks?

2. Orr-Ewing asked Steingard what in him recognized that the suffering was wrong. What in the skeptic you know already points toward God?

3. Keller found doubts he didn’t know he had, and ended up with more peace. Would telling the skeptic you know about your own doubts help or hurt? Why?

Building with those who doubt

Doubt and unbelief aren’t reasons to push away. Just the opposite. Thomas doubted out loud, among the disciples, and Jesus came back for him. A father said “I do believe” and “help me overcome my unbelief” in the same breath, and Jesus did not send him away. Some of the disciples doubted on the mountain, and Jesus sent them out anyway.

And the skeptic isn’t starting from zero. God “has not left himself without testimony” (Acts 14:17). The sense that suffering is wrong, wonder at the world around them, hunger for justice: these are already there.

These vestiges of the image of God are foundations on which we build together. Paul honored the Athenians’ poets, then told them about the man God raised from the dead. Our divine family is made to discover truth together. Even he who is the Truth became our brother in order to build his new kingdom.

THIS WEEK

Practice

1. Pray again, by name, for the person you've been thinking of.
2. Listen for one thing they already care about: justice, beauty, truth, kindness. Tell them you see it.
3. If they share a doubt, thank them before you answer it.

Watch the clips and see every lesson online:
honortheskeptic.stlctrufant.com
Doubters Welcome · Pastor Aaron Frey · Wednesdays at 7:00 PM · Repeated Thursdays at 11:00 AM
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